

THE UNIVERSAL HOUSE OF JUSTICE

1998-05-03

To the conference of the continental counselors

1 beloved friends,

it has been barely two years and four months since you came together

2 here at the outset of your current term of service. in our message to your

3 conference at that time, we described in detail not only the purpose and structure of
the four year plan but the form in which it would have to

4 be pursued if it was to realize its ambitious aim. you were then given the

5 mandate to go forth and prepare the bahá'í world to take on the challenges

6 that lay ahead.

7 The extraordinary events of the convention we have all just witnessed bear

8 eloquent testimony to the ardor and effectiveness of your response. All of the
institutions of the faith have most certainly played their parts in moving our

9 beloved cause a giant step forward in this brief period. The clarity and vigor

10 with which the National Spiritual Assemblies are addressing the tasks of the plan
reflect that dramatic advance in maturity that the guardian encouraged

11 us to expect in these closing years of the century. we feel compelled, however,

12 to pay special tribute to the selfless, inspiring and intelligent contributions

13 which you have made to this collective enterprise. your work has brought

14 honor to your institution and immense joy to our hearts.

As a result of your unceasing activity during the months immediately

15 following the conference, the bahá'í world had been made ready, by the 264.1

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266 1996–2000 • The four Year Plan

267 619time it received our rixván 1996 message, to enter into intensive detailed

268 planning. And once national plans were formulated your efforts did not
 269 slacken; with equal vigor you and your auxiliaries galvanized the believers
 270 into systematic action and helped them to remain focused on the central aim of the
 plan. we hope that you will convey to your Auxiliary board
 271 members and their assistants our heartfelt gratitude.
 272 The challenge which now faces the bahá'í world is to take advantage of
 273 the momentum thus achieved. it has within its grasp the opportunity to
 274 multiply its human resources on a scale far beyond anything heretofore at-tained.
 every measure must be taken to ensure that this possibility becomes
 275 a reality. Training must be offered widely, to contingents of newly enrolled and
 veteran believers alike. it is also imperative that the energies being gen-
 276 erated and the skills being developed through training institute programs be
 277 channelled to serve directly the needs of the plan. in short—without any
 278 delay—the work should move to the higher tempo that recent accomplish-
 279 ments make possible.
 280 your consultations this week need to be eminently practical. you come to
 281 them with a wealth of experience that the bahá'í community has never be-
 282 fore enjoyed. you are well aware of the diverse strengths of the communities
 283 you serve and of the efficacy of the methods being employed in the field. The lessons
 of these past two years need to be examined and correlated,
 284 and their implications for advancing the process of entry by troops must
 285 be understood. in this context, you will also have to consider the increased
 286 capacity of your own institution, the work of the Auxiliary board members,
 287 and your interaction with them, with Spiritual Assemblies, and with the international
 Teaching center, whose concern it is to reinforce your efforts
 288 with advice, perspectives and resources.
 289 dear friends! you represent an army of able and highly motivated servants
 290 of the cause throughout the world. yours is an institution which, in one
 291 respect, has a particularly intimate relationship with the universal house of
 292 justice; in another, it is able to exercise an influence that penetrates the very
 293 grass roots of the community. its nature fits it, uniquely, to serve as a river of
 294 encouragement, example and love whose waters can refresh and invigorate the spirit
 of every believer they touch.

we will follow your consultations this week with the heightened hope

295 and confidence which your impressive achievements to date have awakened. for
your part, be sure of our ardent prayers that bahá'u'lláh will bless your

296 deliberations and confirm your efforts to help bring about the massive 265.4

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266 m e S a g e S f r o m T h e u n i v e r S a l h o u S e o f j u S T i c e

267 620increase in resources which the mission of our beloved cause so urgently

268 requires.

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Training Institutes

[signed: The Universal House of Justice]